systems of the interwar period that were produced by industrialised Western Europe during its worst ever economic crisis, the Great Depression. Nazism and Fascism had elements in common (and with Communism) but they came into existence in the very different social settings of Germany and Italy. The latter country was much poorer and its southern regions were, socially and economically, in a state of near feudalism. What was common to both was the attempt to solve the internal problems of a nation through military expansion, justified by a dangerous nationalistic or even racial ideology. Much more affluent than the Soviet subjects though the majority of them were, Germans and Italians also appeared susceptible to totalitarian ideas. There was something in these three political ideologies of the twentieth century that was radically different from the logic of any previous system of governance or any previous war for territory. Now it was about an ideology that encompassed all walks of life and all people, it was not just about power and land.

Initially, Hitler's and Mussolini's ideas were debated in perfectly respectable circles and had advocates all over Europe, even in democracies like Britain where Mosley's British Union of Fascists was formed. Members of the elites in Germany, Italy and elsewhere in Europe, who were fascinated by Fascism, dismissed its sinister character. 'The fact that fascism could gain political power in Italy and Germany was, to a great extent, a result of the hubris, as much as the cowardice and perfidy, of the social elites,' writes Rob Riemen, to provide parallels with populisms of the twenty-first century. 'The liberals no longer defended the freedom principle of European humanism…' Riemen makes a strong case for the argument that the rise of fascism and of mass-society in Europe then – a variant of pre-World War II populism[42] – was, above all, possible because of the loss of moral values.

In the beginning, some of the Fascist social and economic ideas were accepted as legitimate contributions to the debate about solving the deep problems of Europe at the time. The ultra-nationalistic and racial aspects of the two ideologies were apparently not taken seriously enough. After all, anti-Semitism – albeit not necessarily in its radical racist form – had long been present in Europe, even in its most affluent parts, and needed only to be inflamed and developed further to result finally in the unspeakable horrors of the Holocaust.